

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Schools of Buddhism - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper I, Section B | 32 diagnostics, 16 solved PYQs and 6 original Mains models

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Schools of Buddhism - Solved Practice Workbook

How to use this workbook. Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed independently for each question, so no rotation or predictable sequence can be exploited. Every option carries a question-specific explanation and every question carries a unique examiner trap. The solved previous-year questions reproduce the official printed wording exactly; the model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed independently, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

CORE DIAGNOSTICS - 24 ITEMS

MCQ 1. What the Four Noble Truths are doing

With reference to the Four Noble Truths (*catvāri āryasatyāni*), consider the following statements.

1. The second truth supplies a causal account of how suffering is produced.
2. The third truth is an independent article of faith unconnected with the second.
3. The fourth truth prescribes the discipline by which the causal chain is interrupted.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it retains statement 2, which severs cessation from origination, whereas cessation is precisely what follows once a dependently produced effect loses its condition.
- **B:** Incorrect: keeping statement 2 while dropping statement 1 removes the causal account that alone makes the path in statement 3 intelligible as a therapy.
- **C:** Correct: the second truth gives the dependent arising of suffering and the fourth gives the discipline that breaks it, which is exactly why the third truth is an entailment rather than a hope.
- **D:** Incorrect: statements 1 and 3 are sound, but including 2 contradicts them, since the third truth is derived from the conditionality asserted in the second.

Examiner trap 1: Presenting the four truths as a numbered list rather than as one causal circuit read forward and backward loses the analytical marks the directive is actually testing.

MCQ 2. Three denials that must not be merged

Buddhism is classified as unorthodox (*nāstika*), as non-theistic and as anti-substantialist. These three descriptions respectively rest on its rejection of

- A. Vedic scriptural authority, the explanatory necessity of a creator, and a permanent self behind experience
- B. the moral law of action, the practice of meditation, and the reality of the external world as such
- C. rebirth across lives, the possibility of liberation, and the validity of inference as a means of knowing
- D. renunciation as a way of life, the authority of teachers, and the conventional usefulness of ordinary speech

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the three labels track three distinct denials - of Vedic authority, of a required creator, and of a permanent self - and confusing them produces most classification errors in scripts.
- **B:** Incorrect: Buddhism affirms moral consequence and meditative discipline, and only some Buddhist schools question the external world, so none of these grounds the three labels.
- **C:** Incorrect: Buddhism affirms rebirth without a soul, affirms liberation as its whole purpose, and accepts inference as one of its two means of valid knowledge.
- **D:** Incorrect: renunciation and teachers are central to the tradition, and conventional speech is expressly preserved under the doctrine of conventional truth.

Examiner trap 2: Translating *nāstika* as "atheist" collapses the Veda criterion into the creator criterion and makes Sāṃkhya and Mīmāṃsā, which are non-theistic yet Veda-accepting, unclassifiable.

MCQ 3. What the practical Middle Path actually rejects

In its practical sense, the Middle Path (*madhyamā pratipad*; Pali: *majjhimā paṭipadā*) is best described as

- A. a proportionate blend of moderate enjoyment with moderate austerity, adjusted to the temperament of the practitioner
- B. an instruction to suspend judgement between rival philosophical positions until further evidence becomes available
- C. a rule of social conduct that regulates the relations between the monastic community and lay supporters
- D. a distinct disciplined route that rejects both sensual indulgence and self-mortification because neither removes craving

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the middle is not the average of the extremes; it is a third, positively specified training whose test is causal efficacy against craving rather than balance.
- **B:** Incorrect: suspension of judgement is a sceptical stance, whereas the Middle Path is a definite prescription with eight named factors.
- **C:** Incorrect: monastic and lay relations belong to disciplinary literature, not to the doctrinal content of the first-sermon framework.
- **D:** Correct: both extremes are rejected on the same diagnostic ground - indulgence feeds craving while mortification exhausts the practitioner without touching it - and the replacement is the eightfold training.

Examiner trap 3: Describing the Middle Path as moderation imports an Aristotelian mean and conceals the fact that Buddhism rejects the extremes for failing a causal test, not for being immoderate.

MCQ 4. Grouping the eight factors

The eight factors of the Noble Eightfold Path (*āryāṣṭāṅgamārga*) are classically grouped under three trainings. Right speech, right action and right livelihood belong to

- A. wisdom (*prajñā*), because each of them presupposes a correct view of conditioned things
- B. ethical discipline (*śīla*), because each of them regulates outward conduct that renews the conditions of craving
- C. meditative discipline (*samādhi*), because each of them is practised only during formal periods of sitting
- D. a fourth training of faith, which the tradition adds separately for lay practitioners of the path

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: wisdom covers right view and right intention; conduct factors presuppose wisdom but are not classified under it.
- **B:** Correct: speech, action and livelihood are the conduct factors, and their function is to stop renewing the conditions in which craving is generated.
- **C:** Incorrect: meditative discipline covers right effort, right mindfulness and right concentration, none of which is a conduct factor.
- **D:** Incorrect: the classical grouping is threefold, and no separate training of faith is added to the eightfold scheme.

Examiner trap 4: Listing the eight factors ungrouped reads as recitation; the grouping into wisdom, ethical discipline and meditative discipline is itself the analytical content the examiner is looking for.

MCQ 5. The doctrinal middle

The doctrinal sense of the Middle Path consists in the rejection of

- A. realism about external objects and idealism about consciousness, in favour of a neutral monism of events
- B. inference as an independent means of knowledge and testimony as a derived one, in favour of perception alone
- C. eternalism (*śāśvatavāda*) and annihilationism (*ucchedavāda*), in favour of conditioned continuity without a permanent bearer
- D. asceticism as a monastic ideal and ritual as a lay one, in favour of a purely contemplative discipline

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the realism-idealism dispute divides the four Buddhist schools internally and is not what the doctrinal middle names.
- **B:** Incorrect: that restriction describes the Cārvāka position on knowledge, whereas Buddhism accepts perception and inference alike.
- **C:** Correct: dependent origination denies an unchanging bearer without denying causal continuity, which is exactly the middle between the two named extremes.
- **D:** Incorrect: this restates the practical middle inaccurately and omits the metaphysical pair the doctrinal middle actually rejects.

Examiner trap 5: Treating no-self as a form of annihilationism reverses the doctrine, since annihilationism denies causal continuity while no-self denies only the permanent bearer of it.

MCQ 6. The formula of dependent origination

The standard formula of dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*) is significant for Buddhist soteriology chiefly because

- A. it states positive conditionality and negative conditionality together, so that cessation is built into the principle itself
- B. it identifies a first cause from which the entire series of conditioned phenomena can be shown to proceed
- C. it establishes that every effect pre-exists in its material cause and is merely manifested when conditions mature
- D. it demonstrates that the relation between cause and effect is a matter of habitual expectation rather than of nature

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the four clauses pair presence with arising and absence with cessation, which is why the third Noble Truth follows from the principle rather than being added to it.
- **B:** Incorrect: the doctrine explicitly declines to identify an absolutely first cause, and the wheel image encodes that refusal.
- **C:** Incorrect: the pre-existence of the effect in the cause is the Sāṃkhya thesis of *satkāryavāda*, which Buddhism does not hold.
- **D:** Incorrect: reducing causation to habitual expectation is a Humean position, whereas Buddhism treats conditionality as law-like and objective.

Examiner trap 6: Quoting only the arising half of the formula silently discards the cessation half, which is precisely the half that makes dependent origination a doctrine of liberation.

MCQ 7. The three marks and their scope

With reference to the three marks (*trilakṣaṇa*; Pali: *tilakkhaṇa*), consider the following statements.

1. Impermanence and unsatisfactoriness are standardly predicated of conditioned formations.
2. The mark of no-self is applied more widely than the other two.
3. Impermanence in the early teaching is verbally identical with the later thesis of momentariness.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: statement 3 erases the distinction between the early teaching of impermanence and the stronger scholastic thesis of one-moment duration.
- **B:** Correct: the standard formula restricts the first two marks to conditioned formations while applying not-self more widely, which is why the unconditioned status of cessation is not thereby contradicted.
- **C:** Incorrect: it keeps the false identification in statement 3 and drops the accurate scope claim in statement 1.
- **D:** Incorrect: statements 1 and 2 are correct, but statement 3 conflates an early teaching with a later radicalisation of it.

Examiner trap 7: Inferring from universal impermanence that cessation of conditioned suffering must itself be one more momentary event ignores its classification as unconditioned in important Buddhist traditions.

MCQ 8. The order of the chain

In the twelve-link sequence (*dvādaśa-nidāna*), the correct order of the links immediately following name-and-form (*nāma-rūpa*) is

- A. contact, six sense-bases, craving, feeling
- B. feeling, contact, six sense-bases, craving
- C. six sense-bases, contact, feeling, craving
- D. craving, feeling, six sense-bases, contact

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: contact presupposes the sense-bases through which it occurs, so it cannot precede them, and feeling cannot follow craving.
- **B:** Incorrect: feeling arises from contact and cannot precede it, which reverses the very junction at which the path intervenes.
- **C:** Correct: name-and-form conditions the six sense-bases, which condition contact, which conditions feeling, which conditions craving.
- **D:** Incorrect: this inverts the whole segment and would make craving prior to the sensory conditions that generate it.

Examiner trap 8: Reversing feeling and craving destroys the doctrine's practical bite, because the entire discipline of mindfulness is located precisely in the gap between them.

MCQ 9. Why the chain is not fatalism

Buddhists deny that the twelve-link chain entails fatalism primarily because

- A. the links classified as present causes remain open to alteration, so present practice changes what is subsequently produced
- B. the sequence describes only the experience of unenlightened persons and does not apply to disciplined practitioners
- C. every link may be broken at any point by an act of divine grace conferred independently of the practitioner's effort
- D. the chain is a purely symbolic representation with no claim to describe the actual conditions of rebirth or suffering

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: on the three-life arrangement the past causes and present results are already produced, while craving, clinging and becoming remain open, which is where discipline operates.
- **B:** Incorrect: the chain describes the general conditions of cyclic existence, and a practitioner is precisely someone working within it rather than exempt from it.
- **C:** Incorrect: grace conferred by a deity has no place in a system that treats a creator as explanatorily unnecessary.
- **D:** Incorrect: treating the chain as merely symbolic would remove the causal claim that makes cessation possible at all.

Examiner trap 9: Presenting only the three-life reading suggests a fixed chronology; adding the present-process reading is what shows the chain to be immediately practical.

MCQ 10. The criterion behind momentariness

The Buddhist thesis *yat sat tat kṣaṇikam* is grounded on the prior claim that

- A. whatever is perceived by the senses must be composed of parts and is therefore liable to decomposition
- B. whatever is described by a general term must be a conceptual construction rather than an ultimately real entity
- C. whatever is denied by the opponent must be affirmed by the proponent if the debate is to remain intelligible
- D. whatever is real is capable of producing an effect, so that reality is identified with causal efficacy

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: decomposition of composites is a different argument and would not by itself yield the strict one-moment thesis.
- **B:** Incorrect: this states the exclusion theory of meaning, which concerns universals rather than the temporal duration of the real.
- **C:** Incorrect: this is a debating convention and has no role in establishing an ontological thesis.
- **D:** Correct: the equation of the real with what is capable of an effect is the premise from which the two-horned dilemma against permanence is launched.

Examiner trap 10: Deriving momentariness directly from dependent origination skips the causal-efficacy premise and leaves the derivation demanded by the 2020 question logically incomplete.

MCQ 11. The two horns

In the Buddhist argument against a permanent efficient cause, the horn of simultaneity (*yaugapadya*) presses the objection that

- A. a permanent entity would be unable to enter into any relation with the auxiliary conditions that surround it
- B. a permanent entity would have to be perceived as enduring, whereas perception presents only momentary phases
- C. a permanent entity producing its whole effect at once leaves nothing available for later production
- D. a permanent entity would require a second permanent entity to destroy it when its function is complete

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the inability to relate is not asserted; the argument concedes auxiliaries and then shows that admitting them is fatal in a different way.
- **B:** Incorrect: the argument is inferential rather than perceptual, since no one claims to perceive momentary phases directly.
- **C:** Correct: if the complete power operates at once, later production has no remaining ground, which is exactly the simultaneity horn.
- **D:** Incorrect: this states the separate argument from destruction, which denies that perishing needs an external destroyer.

Examiner trap 11: Presenting momentariness as directly observed misrepresents an argument that works by eliminating the permanent alternative rather than by reporting an experience.

MCQ 12. Closing the Nyāya escape route

Nyāya replies that a permanent substance acts only when auxiliary conditions (*sahakārin*) are present. The Buddhist counter-dilemma is that

- A. either the permanent thing already possesses the power, making auxiliaries idle, or the auxiliaries supply it, making the permanent thing redundant
- B. auxiliary conditions are themselves permanent, so the reply merely postpones the original difficulty by one step
- C. auxiliary conditions cannot be perceived, so their postulation violates the Buddhist restriction to two means of valid knowledge
- D. auxiliary conditions belong to the category of quality, which cannot be causally responsible for the production of a substance

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the *sahakāri-anapekṣā* dilemma exhausts the alternatives, leaving the permanent entity either unnecessary or altered by acquiring a power it lacked.
- **B:** Incorrect: Nyāya does not claim that auxiliaries are permanent, so the reply misses the actual position it is attacking.
- **C:** Incorrect: auxiliaries are ordinary observable conditions, so no epistemological restriction is violated by admitting them.
- **D:** Incorrect: this borrows Vaiśeṣika category language and does not correspond to any step of the Buddhist argument.

Examiner trap 12: Omitting the auxiliary-conditions reply and its closure leaves the momentariness argument looking like an assertion, because the dilemma is the point at which the realist alternative is actually eliminated.

MCQ 13. How continuity survives momentariness

Under momentariness, the appearance of an enduring object is explained by

- A. an underlying substance that persists while its qualities are successively replaced by similar qualities
- B. an act of divine sustenance that maintains resemblance between successive states of the world
- C. a permanent witnessing consciousness before which the succession of states is continuously displayed
- D. a causal series (*santāna*) whose successive members are sufficiently similar to be treated as one thing

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: an underlying persisting substance is precisely the Nyāya position the Buddhist argument has just eliminated.
- **B:** Incorrect: divine sustenance is unavailable in a system that treats a creator as explanatorily unnecessary.
- **C:** Incorrect: a permanent witness is the Advaitic device, and importing it would abandon no-self altogether.
- **D:** Correct: continuity is carried by causal succession plus similarity, which is what the flame and stream illustrations are used to convey.

Examiner trap 13: Explaining continuity by quietly reintroducing a subtle self converts the Buddhist answer into the position it was designed to refute; the device is always the series, never a bearer.

MCQ 14. The exhaustive analysis of the person

The philosophical force of the five-aggregate (*pañca-skandha*) analysis lies in the fact that

- A. the enumeration is claimed to be exhaustive, so that failure to find a sixth item is failure to find a self
- B. each aggregate is shown to be permanent in substance while impermanent in its successive modes
- C. the aggregates are ranked hierarchically, with consciousness serving as the owner of the remaining four
- D. the analysis is presented as a provisional teaching device that a more advanced practitioner may discard

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the doctrine stands or falls on exhaustiveness, since a further category would restore the very owner the analysis claims cannot be found.
- **B:** Incorrect: permanence of substance with changing modes is the Jaina definition of the real, which Buddhism explicitly rejects.
- **C:** Incorrect: consciousness is one aggregate among five and is examined and found not-self along with the others.
- **D:** Incorrect: the analysis is doctrinally central rather than provisional, and it is the standard route to the printed no-self thesis.

Examiner trap 14: Defining no-self without enumerating the aggregates removes the argument and leaves only the conclusion, which is why such answers read as assertion rather than demonstration.

MCQ 15. What the chariot analogy establishes

In the chariot analogy of the *Milinda-pañha*, the philosophical point is that

- A. the chariot is wholly unreal, so that anyone who uses the word is making a straightforward factual mistake
- B. the chariot is identical with the sum of its parts arranged in a heap, so that the arrangement contributes nothing
- C. the term functions correctly as a designation without naming any further entity beyond the parts and their arrangement
- D. the chariot possesses a distinct nature that emerges from the parts and thereafter exists independently of them

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the analogy preserves ordinary usage, since the chariot can still be driven, purchased and repaired.
- **B:** Incorrect: a mere heap is expressly denied to be a chariot, which is why arrangement and function are part of the account.
- **C:** Correct: the analogy makes a semantic point - a term can be true without being referential to an additional item - and that is what protects the conventional person.
- **D:** Incorrect: an emergent independent nature would be a *svabhāva*, which the analogy is designed to exclude.

Examiner trap 15: Using the chariot to prove that the person is unreal overshoots the analogy and invites the charge that Buddhism cannot account for practice, ethics or refuge.

MCQ 16. Two no-selves, precisely distinguished

Personal no-self (*pudgala-nairātmya*) and phenomenon no-self (*dharma-nairātmya*) are related as follows.

- A. Both are equally emphasised by every Buddhist school, so the distinction has only terminological significance
- B. The first denies the reality of external objects while the second denies the reality of internal mental states
- C. The first is a Mahāyāna innovation while the second belongs to the earliest strata of Buddhist teaching
- D. The first denies an enduring person, while the second extends the denial to intrinsic nature in the constituent factors

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: realist Abhidharma schools accept the first while treating *dharma*s as ultimately real, so the distinction is substantive.
- **B:** Incorrect: the division is not between outer and inner but between the owner and the inventory on which the owner was denied.
- **C:** Incorrect: the order is reversed, since personal no-self is the shared minimum thesis and the extension to *dharma*s is developed emphatically in Mahāyāna.
- **D:** Correct: the second applies the same analytic pressure to the factors themselves, which is why it is stressed most strongly by Mādhyamika.

Examiner trap 16: Treating the two theses as equivalent erases exactly the difference of scope that the 2021 question was framed to test.

MCQ 17. Moral consequence without a permanent self

The Buddhist formula that the later stage is "neither the same nor another" (*na sa eva na cānyaḥ*) is philosophically necessary because

- A. strict identity would preserve responsibility while strict difference would preserve impermanence, so both must be affirmed together
- B. strict identity would reinstate eternalism while strict difference would make the fruit fall on an unrelated recipient
- C. strict identity is asserted at the conventional level while strict difference is asserted at the ultimate level
- D. strict identity is a Nyāya doctrine while strict difference is a Sāṃkhya doctrine, so both must be rejected as non-Buddhist

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: affirming both together would be straightforwardly contradictory, whereas the formula denies both in favour of causal continuity.
- **B:** Correct: the formula is a middle precisely because each extreme destroys one of the things Buddhism wishes to keep - impermanence on one side, responsibility on the other.
- **C:** Incorrect: the two-truths distinction is not used to distribute identity and difference across levels in this way.
- **D:** Incorrect: the rejection is argued from internal consequences, not from the schools that happen to hold the positions.

Examiner trap 17: Locating moral quality in outward action rather than in intention (*ceṭanā*) removes the aggregate in which Buddhism actually places moral responsibility.

MCQ 18. What cessation of conditioned suffering is

Cessation of conditioned suffering (*nirvāṇa*; Pali: *nibbāna*) is most accurately described as

- A. the extinction of attachment, aversion and delusion, and thereby the ceasing of the process that produces suffering
- B. the attainment by the liberated self of a permanent state of undisturbed bliss in a region beyond the world
- C. the complete annihilation of the individual, understood as the destruction of a substance that formerly existed
- D. the merging of individual consciousness into a universal consciousness from which it had been temporarily separated

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the three fires are what is extinguished, and what ceases is the conditioned production of suffering rather than an entity.
- **B:** Incorrect: this reinstates both the self and a place, each of which the doctrine expressly declines to posit.
- **C:** Incorrect: annihilation presupposes a substance to annihilate, and no such substance was ever admitted.
- **D:** Incorrect: merging into a universal consciousness is an Advaitic formulation and is precisely the crypto-Advaita reading the tradition resists.

Examiner trap 18: Treating the classification of *nirvāṇa* as unconditioned (*asaṃskṛta*) as evidence for an eternal self confuses being outside the dependent series with being a substance.

MCQ 19. The internal relation of the Three Jewels

In the Buddhist account of the Three Jewels (*Triratna*), the internal relation among Buddha, Dharma and Saṅgha is best stated as

- A. three independent objects of devotion, each sufficient on its own to secure liberation for the practitioner
- B. a hierarchy in which the community confers authority on the teaching and the teaching confers authority on the teacher
- C. a symbolic triad with no doctrinal content, retained only because the formula of refuge is ritually convenient
- D. a functional triad in which the teacher discovered the path, the teaching liberates, and the community preserves and transmits it

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the three are interdependent in function, and treating each as independently sufficient misstates the structure of refuge.
- **B:** Incorrect: the direction of origin runs from the teacher through the teaching to the community, even though access today runs the other way.
- **C:** Incorrect: the triad carries substantive doctrinal content, since what liberates is identified as the teaching rather than as devotion to a person.
- **D:** Correct: this states both the origin relation and the transmission relation, which is exactly what a question on internal relation is asking for.

Examiner trap 19: Arguing that refuge presupposes a soul misses the reply that the refuge-taker is the conventional designated person, which is all that being conditioned by instruction requires.

MCQ 20. Vaibhāṣika realism and its cost

The Vaibhāṣika affirmation that *dharmas* of the past, present and future have some mode of existence is best explained as

- A. an acceptance of an eternal substance underlying the momentary states in which it successively appears
- B. a device required to keep past acts able to bear future fruit and to give every cognition a genuine object
- C. a concession to Mahāyāna criticism that the momentary ontology of the earlier schools was too austere
- D. an inference from the impossibility of partless atoms combining to form perceptible gross objects

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: no eternal substance is admitted; what is claimed is a mode of existence for *dharmas* across the three times.
- **B:** Correct: both the karmic relation and the cognitive relation need two relata, and extending existence across the three times is how Vaibhāṣika supplies them.
- **C:** Incorrect: the thesis belongs to the Sarvāstivāda tradition on its own account and is not a response to Mahāyāna pressure.
- **D:** Incorrect: the atom argument is a Yogācāra weapon against external realism and does not support the three-times thesis.

Examiner trap 20: Reading *sarvam asti* as eternalism ignores the further Vaibhāṣika claim that only present *dharmas* possess the distinctive present efficacy.

MCQ 21. The Sautrāntika argument

Sautrāntika concludes that external objects are known only inferentially because

- A. the senses are unreliable instruments whose deliverances must always be corrected by scriptural testimony
- B. external objects are ultimately unreal, so any cognition of them must be a construction of the mind alone
- C. universals cannot be perceived, and therefore no cognition of a general object can ever be perceptual
- D. the object-moment has already ceased when the cognition it caused arises, so cognition can only bear its form

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: scriptural correction of the senses plays no part in the argument, which turns entirely on momentariness and causal order.
- **B:** Incorrect: Sautrāntika is a realist school that affirms external objects and disputes only the mode of access to them.
- **C:** Incorrect: this concerns universals rather than external particulars and belongs to the theory of exclusion.
- **D:** Correct: momentariness plus the requirement that a cause precede its effect yields a time-gap, so cognition presents a form from which the object is inferred.

Examiner trap 21: Classifying Sautrāntika as sceptical about the external world confuses a claim about access with a claim about existence and destroys its role as the realist half of the 2024 contrast.

MCQ 22. How Yogācāra argues against external realism

Consider the following Yogācāra arguments against external realism.

1. The dream argument, which shows that a complete world-appearance needs no external correlate.
2. The atom critique, which shows that partless atoms cannot combine while composite ones are not ultimate.
3. The time-gap argument, which shows that the inferred external object performs no explanatory work.

Which of the above arguments does Yogācāra employ?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 1 and 3 only

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it omits the time-gap argument, which is the argument Yogācāra takes over from Sautrāntika and turns against it.
- **B:** Incorrect: it omits the dream argument, which is the school's best-known move and the one that removes the evidential basis of realism.
- **C:** Correct: all three are used, and they divide labour by attacking realism's evidence, its coherence and its explanatory role respectively.
- **D:** Incorrect: it omits the atom critique, which is the argument directed specifically at the realist account of gross objects.

Examiner trap 22: Giving only the dream argument leaves the position looking like an appeal to a single analogy, whereas the strength of the school lies in the convergence of three independent lines.

MCQ 23. The three natures

In Yogācāra, the imagined (*parikalpita*), dependent (*paratantra*) and perfected (*pariniṣpanna*) natures are best understood as

- A. three descriptions of one dependent flow - as falsely taken, as actually running, and as truly seen
- B. three distinct realities arranged in ascending order, the lowest being annihilated when the highest is realised
- C. three stages of meditative attainment, corresponding to concentration, insight and final absorption
- D. three types of cognition, corresponding respectively to perception, inference and testimony

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the three natures describe the same flow under a superimposed duality, in its actual conditioned running, and as realised free of that superimposition.
- **B:** Incorrect: treating them as three entities multiplies realities and invites the objection that Yogācāra abandons its own economy.
- **C:** Incorrect: they are an analysis of how objectification arises and is removed, not a graded ladder of meditative states.
- **D:** Incorrect: the Buddhist means-of-knowledge school admits only two means, and the three natures are not a classification of them.

Examiner trap 23: Presenting the three natures as three worlds makes liberation look like the acquisition of a new object rather than the withdrawal of a superimposition.

MCQ 24. From dependence to emptiness

The Mādhyamika derivation of emptiness (*śūnyatā*) from dependent origination turns on the premise that

- A. whatever is composite must eventually decompose, so that no composite thing can be counted as ultimately real
- B. whatever possesses intrinsic nature (*svabhāva*) would exist through itself and would therefore not depend on conditions
- C. whatever is cognised must be identical with the cognition of it, so that no object stands outside awareness
- D. whatever is expressed by a word must be a construction, so that only the ineffable particular can be ultimately real

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: decomposition of composites is a weaker argument and would not touch simples, which the emptiness thesis also covers.
- **B:** Correct: independence is built into the very concept of intrinsic nature, so dependence excludes it and emptiness follows immediately.
- **C:** Incorrect: the identity of object and cognition is a Yogācāra thesis that Mādhyamika criticises as a further reification.
- **D:** Incorrect: this states the Buddhist theory of the unique particular and belongs to epistemology rather than to the emptiness derivation.

Examiner trap 24: Omitting the two truths from an emptiness answer makes the doctrine read as nihilism, which is exactly the misreading Nāgārjuna warns against with the image of the wrongly seized snake.

REMEDIAL DRILLS - 8 ERROR-TARGETING ITEMS

MCQ 25. The label that is not a name

Which of the following statements about Buddhist tradition-labels is accurate?

- A. Theravāda, Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika are three names for a single school opposed to a uniform Mahāyāna system
- B. "Hīnayāna" was the shared self-designation of the early schools before Mahāyāna adopted a different name
- C. Vaibhāṣika and Yogācāra are Theravāda formations, while Sautrāntika and Mādhyamika are Mahāyāna formations
- D. Theravāda is one surviving school with the Pali canon, while Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika belong to the Sarvāstivāda world

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the three are distinct, with different canons and doctrines, and Mahāyāna is itself internally diverse rather than uniform.
- **B:** Incorrect: the label was applied by Mahāyāna authors to disciple-vehicle traditions and was not adopted by them as a self-description.
- **C:** Incorrect: it scrambles the placements, since Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika are non-Mahāyāna while Yogācāra and Mādhyamika are Mahāyāna.
- **D:** Correct: this states the placements accurately and keeps the Pali canonical tradition distinct from the Sanskrit, Chinese and Tibetan transmission of Sarvāstivāda material.

Examiner trap 25: Writing "Hīnayāna (Theravāda)" repeats a polemical classification as though it were a neutral synonym and simultaneously misplaces two of the four philosophical schools.

MCQ 26. Store-consciousness is not a self

Store-consciousness (*ālaya-vijñāna*) differs from the self (*ātman*) rejected by Buddhism because it is

- A. imperceptible to ordinary cognition and therefore knowable only through the testimony of an authoritative teacher
- B. a conditioned and continually transforming stream that carries seeds rather than an unchanging substantial owner
- C. shared among all sentient beings as a single cosmic reservoir in which individual experience is temporarily located
- D. confined to the present life and destroyed at death, so that it cannot support rebirth or moral consequence

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the difference is ontological rather than epistemic, and testimony is not an independent means of knowledge in this school.
- **B:** Correct: being conditioned and transforming is precisely what distinguishes it from a permanent bearer, which is why it does not violate no-self.
- **C:** Incorrect: a single cosmic reservoir would be closer to an absolute consciousness and would abandon the school's anti-substantialism.
- **D:** Incorrect: it is invoked precisely to explain continuity across death, which a stream destroyed at death could not do.

Examiner trap 26: Calling store-consciousness a Buddhist soul concedes the Madhyamaka objection that Yogācāra reifies consciousness, without noticing that Yogācāra itself insists on its conditioned character.

MCQ 27. Emptiness and nihilism

The doctrine of two truths is indispensable to Madhyamaka because it

- A. preserves persons, causation, moral consequence and practice at the conventional level while denying intrinsic nature at the ultimate level
- B. establishes that conventional truth is simply false and must be abandoned once ultimate truth has been realised by the practitioner
- C. demonstrates that ultimate truth is a higher reality behind appearances, into which empty phenomena are finally resolved
- D. proves that the two levels contradict each other, which is why Madhyamaka is willing to abandon the law of non-contradiction

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the conventional level is where practice, ethics and language operate, and preserving it is exactly what blocks the nihilist reading.
- **B:** Incorrect: conventional truth is not mere falsehood but the operative domain of Buddhist discipline itself.
- **C:** Incorrect: positing a higher reality behind appearances would install the substrate that emptiness of emptiness is designed to prevent.
- **D:** Incorrect: Madhyamaka does not abandon non-contradiction; its negations are scoped to things taken as self-established.

Examiner trap 27: Equating emptiness with Advaita *Brahman* converts an anti-substantialist doctrine into an absolute-substantialist one and reverses its central claim.

MCQ 28. The type of negation

Madhyamaka denial of all four corners of the *catuṣkoṭi* avoids contradiction because the negation employed is

- A. implicative (*paryudāsa-pratiṣedha*), so that denying each corner asserts the remaining alternatives in turn
- B. merely rhetorical, so that the denials are not intended as claims and carry no philosophical commitment at all
- C. non-implicative (*prasajya-pratiṣedha*) and scoped to things taken as possessing intrinsic nature, so no fifth thesis is installed
- D. provisional, so that the denials are withdrawn once the opponent has been silenced in the course of debate

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: implicative negation would indeed assert alternatives and would make the fourfold denial self-contradictory.
- **B:** Incorrect: the denials are genuine philosophical claims about the incoherence of intrinsic nature, not debating rhetoric.
- **C:** Correct: the negation withdraws a malformed question rather than asserting an alternative, and the scope restriction is what makes this coherent.
- **D:** Incorrect: the denials are not withdrawn, and the "no thesis" claim is defended precisely as a stable position.

Examiner trap 28: Writing that Nāgārjuna rejects logic mistakes a scoped non-implicative negation for irrationalism and forfeits the reply to the self-refutation charge.

MCQ 29. Buddhist means of knowledge

The Buddhist restriction to two means of valid knowledge (*pramāṇa*) is argued from

- A. the practical observation that comparison and testimony rarely yield certainty in ordinary human affairs
- B. the claim that the number of means of knowing is fixed by the number of kinds of object there are to be known
- C. the scriptural authority of the Buddha, whose word settles disputes about the correct enumeration of knowledge-sources
- D. the impossibility of establishing invariable concomitance, which restricts valid knowledge to immediate perception

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the argument is not statistical or practical but structural, resting on a division of possible objects.
- **B:** Correct: there are held to be exactly two object-types, the unique particular and the constructed general character, so exactly two means correspond to them.
- **C:** Incorrect: the school argues the point philosophically and does not treat testimony as an independent authoritative means.
- **D:** Incorrect: denying invariable concomitance and restricting knowledge to perception is the Cārvāka position, not the Buddhist one.

Examiner trap 29: Describing Buddhist logic as Nyāya logic with a shorter list ignores that it rests on momentary particulars, exclusion and the denial of an enduring knower.

MCQ 30. Exclusion and its critics

The objection that the exclusion theory of meaning (*apoha*) is circular holds that

- A. exclusion cannot apply to negative terms, since there is no positive class from which the exclusion could be made
- B. exclusion presupposes momentariness, which has not itself been established independently of the theory of meaning
- C. excluding non-cows presupposes already knowing what a cow is, so the account assumes what it set out to explain
- D. exclusion applies only to words and not to concepts, so it cannot explain the generality present in thought itself

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: negative terms are not the difficulty raised by Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa and Uddyotakara against the theory.
- **B:** Incorrect: momentariness is argued independently through causal efficacy and is not the target of the circularity charge.
- **C:** Correct: this is the standard charge, and Dharmakīrti's reply appeals to shared causal capacity rather than to a prior grasp of a universal.
- **D:** Incorrect: the theory is expressly about conceptual generality as well as about words, so the restriction is not one it accepts.

Examiner trap 30: Declaring the circularity objection dissolved overstates the reply, since many critics hold that causal convergence explains classification without explaining positive determinate cognition.

MCQ 31. Reading the silence

The most defensible reading of the Buddha's refusal to answer the undeclared (*avyākṛta*) questions is that

- A. he lacked the relevant knowledge, which is why the tradition preserves the questions without preserving answers
- B. the questions were reserved for advanced disciples and were answered privately outside the public discourses
- C. the questions were philosophically trivial and were dismissed because they had no bearing on any doctrine
- D. the questions are both unconvincing to liberation and defective in presupposing a substantial self or world

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the agnostic reading fits poorly with the strong positive teaching of suffering, its origin, its cessation and the path.
- **B:** Incorrect: no doctrine of a private answer is offered, and the arrow parable gives a stated reason for the refusal itself.
- **C:** Incorrect: the questions are treated as seriously misleading rather than trivial, since answering them would concede an extreme.
- **D:** Correct: combining the therapeutic reason given in the arrow parable with the presuppositional defect is the reading best supported by the sources and by no-self.

Examiner trap 31: Reading the fire-going-out simile as a hidden self departing in some direction inverts its point, which is that directional predication lapses once the sustaining conditions cease.

MCQ 32. The comparison most often written wrongly

In comparing Buddhism with Jainism, which of the following is accurate?

- A. Both deny the soul, but Jainism explains continuity by karmic matter while Buddhism explains it by a causal series
- B. Both reject a creator God, but Jainism affirms a real conscious soul while Buddhism denies any permanent self
- C. Both affirm a permanent self, but Jainism treats it as omniscient while Buddhism treats it as momentary in nature
- D. Both accept Vedic authority, but Jainism restricts it to ethics while Buddhism restricts it to meditative practice

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: its first clause is false, since Jainism affirms the soul emphatically, even though its account of karmic matter is correctly described.
- **B:** Correct: the shared rejection of a creator is genuine, and the decisive contrast is that the Jaina *jīva* is real and intrinsically conscious while Buddhism denies any such substance.
- **C:** Incorrect: Buddhism affirms no permanent self at all, so the shared premise of the option is false.
- **D:** Incorrect: both traditions are classified as unorthodox precisely because they reject Vedic authority.

Examiner trap 32: Saying that Buddhism and Jainism both deny the soul is the single most frequently penalised comparison error in the topic, because it erases the pluralist realism that defines Jainism.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Practice status and source discipline - read once, applies to every solution below

Verified wording. Every previous-year question below is reproduced exactly as printed in the held UPSC Civil Services (Main) Philosophy Paper I question papers, 2018-2025, with the year, question number and marks as printed. **No official key exists in the repository for these descriptive questions.** The model answers are independent learner practice written to the stated word band and directive. They are never presented as official UPSC keys, and no objective answer letter is asserted for any descriptive question. **Ownership.** Thirteen of the sixteen solved questions are primary-owned by Buddhism. Three are primary-owned elsewhere - two by Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika and one by Cārvāka - and are solved here because the Buddhist half of each is owned by this topic and is the half most often written badly. **Word bands used.** 10 marks: 150-200 words. 15 marks: 250-300 words. 20 marks: 340-400 words.

VERIFIED PREVIOUS-YEAR QUESTIONS - SIXTEEN COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

PYQ 1 · 2018 · Q5(b) · 10 marks · Buddhism

Question, as printed: How do the Mādhyamika Buddhists apply the notion of Pratītyasamutpāda to establish their doctrine of Śūnyatā? Discuss.

Demand decoded. The hinge word is "apply". The examiner wants a derivation, not two definitions placed side by side. Show that emptiness is *extracted from* dependent origination, and protect the conclusion from nihilism.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

For Mādhyamika, dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*) means that whatever arises does so only in dependence on causes, conditions, parts and conceptual designation. Nāgārjuna converts this causal principle into an ontological one in six steps.

To possess intrinsic nature (*svabhāva*) is to exist through oneself; what exists through itself does not await conditions; but everything conditioned arises in dependence on conditions; therefore nothing conditioned possesses intrinsic nature; to lack intrinsic nature is to be empty; therefore whatever is dependently arisen is empty (*śūnya*). Nāgārjuna accordingly identifies the dependently arisen with the empty.

Emptiness is therefore not non-being. A chariot, a flame or a person functions perfectly well while being undiscoverable as a self-grounded substance. The two truths secure this: at conventional truth (*saṃvṛti-satya*) persons, moral consequence and compassion operate; at ultimate truth (*paramārtha-satya*) no *dharma* has own-being. Even emptiness is empty, being itself a dependent designation rather than a hidden absolute.

The application is thus strict: dependence excludes independence, and emptiness names exactly that exclusion.

Why this earns marks. It gives the derivation as a numbered inference rather than as an assertion, defines *svabhāva* instead of leaving emptiness as a slogan, and closes the nihilism exit with the two truths and the emptiness of emptiness.

PYQ 2 · 2018 · Q6(b) · 15 marks · Buddhism

Question, as printed: Is it consistent for the Buddhists to admit the theory of Nairātmyavāda and the doctrine of Nirvāṇa simultaneously? Give reasons in favour of your answer.

Demand decoded. "Give reasons in favour" fixes the verdict direction: argue for consistency. But a bare defence scores less than a defence that first shows why the objection seems compelling and then dissolves it.

Model answer (15 marks, 250-300 words).

The objection has real force. If no permanent self exists, it seems there is no one to be bound, no one to practise and no one to be liberated; and if everything is momentary, nothing survives to enjoy liberation. Śaṅkara-type Advaita and Nyāya both press this.

The Buddhist reply begins by exposing a presupposition. The question "who attains *nirvāṇa*?" already assumes the substantial claimant whose removal *is* the liberation. Cessation of conditioned suffering is not a possession acquired by an owner; it is the extinction of attachment (*rāga*), aversion (*dveṣa*) and delusion (*moha*), and therefore the ceasing of the process that manufactures suffering.

Once this is seen, no permanent self (*nairātmyavāda*) is not an obstacle to liberation but its condition. Ignorance superimposes "I" and "mine" on the five aggregates; that appropriation generates craving, clinging and renewed becoming. Insight into no-self removes the cognitive basis of appropriation, and the chain loses its fuel.

Momentariness supplies the complementary explanation: only a series of conditioned events can be interrupted by withdrawing a condition, whereas a permanent bondage would be permanent.

Continuity of practice is preserved by the causal continuum (*santāna*). The later liberated stream is neither numerically identical with nor wholly unrelated to the earlier bound stream, exactly as one lamp lights another. Theravāda classifications treat *nibbāna* as unconditioned (*asaṃskṛta*) without making it the state of an eternal self; Nāgārjuna adds that *saṃsāra* and *nirvāṇa* are not two independent realms.

One pressure survives: the first-person claim "I am liberated" is explained only as a conventional index within the stream. That is a cost, not a contradiction - so the two doctrines are consistent, and mutually required.

Why this earns marks. It states the objection at full strength, answers by exposing a presupposition rather than by defending, shows that the doctrines are mutually supporting rather than merely compatible, and ends with a qualified verdict that matches the directive.

PYQ 3 · 2019 · Q5(b) · 10 marks · Buddhism

Question, as printed: How do the Yogācāra Buddhists deny the existence of the external world? Discuss.

Demand decoded. "How" asks for arguments, not for a translation of *vijñaptimātra*. Three distinct arguments plus one sentence protecting the school from solipsism is a complete answer at this length.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

Yogācāra advances representation-only (*vijñaptimātra*): what is given is cognition-as-presentation, not an independently established object. Three arguments support the denial and divide labour.

The **dream argument** removes realism's evidence: a dream supplies depth, objects and an apparent perceiver without any external correlate, so the mere fact that experience *appears* outer cannot prove an outer cause. The **atom critique** removes its coherence: partless atoms have no sides with which to combine, while atoms with parts are not ultimate, so the realist account of gross objects is unstable. The **time-gap argument**, taken from Sautrāntika and pressed further, removes its explanatory role: since object and cognition are momentary, the object has already ceased when its cognition arises, leaving only its form - so the inferred external cause does no work.

Order is then explained internally. Store-consciousness (*ālaya-vijñāna*) carries karmic seeds (*bīja*) whose maturation produces regular, shared experience; the world is intersubjective because karmically co-conditioned, not because one ego invents it.

The denial is therefore of *independent establishment*, not of causal order.

Why this earns marks. It supplies three arguments with distinct functions instead of one analogy, names the store-consciousness mechanism that keeps the position from collapsing into solipsism, and states the thesis in its defensible form.

PYQ 4 · 2019 · Q7(c) · 15 marks · Buddhism

Question, as printed: What is Pratītyasamutpāda? How do the Buddhists apply this concept to prove that everything is momentary?

Demand decoded. Two explicit demands: define, then derive. The derivation is where marks are won or lost, because dependence alone yields impermanence and not strict momentariness.

Model answer (15 marks, 250-300 words).

Dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*) is the principle that whatever arises, arises in dependence on causes and conditions, and ceases when those conditions cease: *this being, that becomes; from the cessation of this, that ceases*. Its primary subject-matter is the arising and cessation of suffering, and it supplies the causal grammar of the second and third Noble Truths.

The derivation of momentariness proceeds in two stages, and conflating them is the standard error.

Stage one is immediate. What depends on conditions cannot remain numerically identical through all times, because it alters as those conditions rise and fall. Therefore whatever is conditioned is impermanent (*anitya*).

Stage two requires an added premise from the Buddhist logicians: to be real is to be capable of producing an effect (*sat = arthakriyā-samartha*). A wholly permanent entity cannot satisfy this. If it produces its whole effect at once, nothing remains for later production - the simultaneity horn (*yaugapadya*). If it produces effects successively, it functions differently at different times, and what functions differently has changed - the succession horn (*krama*). Nyāya's escape, that it acts when auxiliary conditions (*sahakārin*) are present, is closed by the *sahakāri-anapekṣā* dilemma: either the permanent thing already had the power, so the auxiliaries are idle, or the auxiliaries supply it, so the permanent thing is redundant. Hence *yat sat tat kṣaṇikam*.

Continuity is preserved, not denied: the causal series (*santāna*) with similarity (*sādrśya*) explains why a flame or a river looks like one thing.

Critically, Nyāya's counter-charge - that a series explains succession but not the ownership of memory and desert - retains force, so the derivation is powerful without being uncontested.

Why this earns marks. It separates the two stages of the derivation, names both horns and the dilemma that closes the realist escape, retains the continuity device, and ends with the residual objection rather than an unqualified claim.

PYQ 5 · 2020 · Q6(a) · 20 marks · Buddhism

Question, as printed: How is Kṣaṇikavāda a logical derivative of Pratītyasamutpāda in Buddhism? Explain.

Demand decoded. "Logical derivative" is the operative phrase: the examiner wants an inference reconstructed, with its premises exposed. "Explain" permits exposition but rewards the candidate who shows exactly what dependence does and does not by itself deliver.

Model answer (20 marks, 340-400 words).

Dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*) states that whatever arises does so in dependence on conditions and ceases when they cease. Momentariness (*kṣaṇikavāda*) states that whatever is real is momentary. The second is a derivative of the first, but the derivation has two stages and an added premise, and an answer that hides the premise misrepresents the logic.

Stage one: from dependence to impermanence. If a thing arises only when conditions cooperate, its being is indexed to those conditions. Conditions rise and fall; the thing alters with them; therefore it cannot remain numerically identical through all times. So whatever is conditioned is impermanent (*anitya*). This much is already contained in the three marks (*trilakṣaṇa*).

Stage two: from impermanence to strict momentariness. Impermanence permits long-lived changing things; momentariness does not. The extra premise is the Buddhist criterion of reality: to be real is to be capable of producing an effect, *sat = arthakriyā-samartha*. From it the logicians construct a dilemma against any permanent efficient cause. Either it produces its whole effect simultaneously, in which case nothing is left for later production (*yaugapadya*); or it produces successively, in which case it functions differently at different moments, and what functions differently is not wholly unchanged (*krama*). Nyāya replies that the permanent substance acts when auxiliary conditions (*sahakārin*) obtain; the *sahakāri-anapekṣā* dilemma closes this, since either the thing already possessed the power, making auxiliaries idle, or the auxiliaries supply it, making the permanent thing causally redundant. A second line adds that perishing needs no external destroyer: arising already contains ceasing. Therefore *yat sat tat kṣaṇikam*.

What is preserved. The doctrine is not annihilationism. Apparent persistence is explained by the causal series (*santāna*), whose successive members are similar enough (*sādṛśya*) to be designated as one thing - the flame and the stream. Memory, moral consequence and rebirth are carried by the same series.

Verdict. The derivation is genuinely logical rather than merely historical, but it is conditional on the criterion of the real. Nyāya's most effective counter is therefore criterial rather than perceptual: it refuses to identify reality with causal efficacy, and it presses that a series cannot own memory or desert. Momentariness stands as the strongest Buddhist argument against substance, while remaining hostage to a premise its opponents deny.

Why this earns marks. It answers "logical derivative" by exhibiting the inference in two stages, exposes the hidden premise that most scripts suppress, closes the realist escape route by name, preserves continuity, and delivers a conditional verdict rather than a summary.

Question, as printed: How does Buddhism explain Self in terms of Pañcaskandhas? What is Liberation for Buddhism if there is no Soul?

Demand decoded. Two demands joined by a challenge. Enumerate and *use* the aggregates, then answer the challenge directly instead of restating no-self.

Model answer (15 marks, 250-300 words).

Buddhism replaces the question "what is the self?" with an exhaustive inventory. The person is analysed into five aggregates (*pañca-skandha*): form or material body (*rūpa*), feeling (*vedanā*), perception or recognition (*saṃjñā*), dispositions or formations (*saṃskāra*), and consciousness (*vijñāna*).

Each is examined and found impermanent; what is impermanent and appropriated is unsatisfactory; and what is impermanent and unsatisfactory is not fit to be regarded as "this is mine, this I am, this is my self". No sixth item is discovered behind or above them. "Self" is therefore a designation (*prajñapti*) made upon the aggregates, not a discovery among them. The chariot analogy of the *Milinda-pañha* makes the semantic point precisely: "chariot" is correct usage without naming an extra entity beyond parts in working arrangement.

The force of the argument depends entirely on the enumeration being exhaustive, which is why the *Puggalavāda* of the Vātsīputrīyas - a person neither identical with nor different from the aggregates - was rejected as a relapse into self-theory.

Liberation follows without a soul. Cessation of conditioned suffering (*nirvāṇa*) is the extinction of attachment, aversion and delusion, and thereby the ceasing of the process that produces suffering. Ignorance superimposes ownership on the aggregate-stream; that appropriation generates craving and renewed becoming; insight into no-self withdraws the appropriation and the process runs down. Practice is carried by the causal series (*santāna*), and the practitioner is the conventional person, which is all that discipline requires.

The residual difficulty is that a series explains succession more easily than ownership; Buddhism answers by treating ownership as a conventional designation rather than an ultimate fact.

Why this earns marks. It enumerates the aggregates and then uses them as an argument, supplies the semantic reading of the chariot, cites the rejected internal foil as evidence of principled cost, and answers the liberation challenge by redescribing liberation rather than by denying the difficulty.

PYQ 7 · 2021 · Q5(d) · 10 marks · Buddhism

Question, as printed: Distinguish between pudgala-nairātmyavāda and dharma-nairātmyavāda with reference to Buddhist Philosophy.

Demand decoded. "Distinguish" requires criteria, not two paragraphs. Fix the axes - what is denied, by whom, and with what consequence - and the answer writes itself.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

Both are forms of no-self, differing in **scope**.

Personal no-self (pudgala-nairātmya) denies a permanent, independent person (*pudgala*) behind experience. The person is a designation on the five aggregates, and no owner is found among or behind them. This is the minimum thesis shared across Buddhist traditions, and it is what the chariot analogy establishes.

Phenomenon no-self (dharma-nairātmya) extends the same analysis to the constituent factors themselves, denying that any *dharma* possesses intrinsic nature (*svabhāva*).

The difference is therefore between the **owner** and the **inventory** on which the owner was denied. Early Buddhism and the realist Abhidharma schools accept the first while treating *dharma*s as ultimately real; Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika are precisely such positions. Mahāyāna, and Mādhyamika above all, presses the second, which is why dependence yields emptiness there but conditioned realism in the earlier schools.

The distinction is one of philosophical scope, not of institutional affiliation, and it should not be converted into a contrast between Theravāda and Mahāyāna as wholes.

Why this earns marks. It fixes a single criterion of distinction, attaches each thesis to the schools that stress it, connects the difference to the divergent conclusions drawn from dependent origination, and adds the qualification that blocks the standard mislabelling.

PYQ 8 · 2021 · Q7(b) · 15 marks · Buddhism

Question, as printed: If everything is momentary then how do the Buddhists explain the problem of memory and personal identity? Critically discuss.

Demand decoded. "Critically discuss" makes the residual objection compulsory. State the Nyāya case at full strength, give the Buddhist devices by name, and close with an honest verdict.

Model answer (15 marks, 250-300 words).

The Nyāya objection, in the line of Vātsyāyana, Uddyotakara and Udayana, is sharp. If every mental state perishes instantly, the state that remembers is not the state that experienced, so there is no rememberer. Recognition (*pratyabhijñā*) - "this is that same jar", "I am the one who saw it" - appears to disclose identity through time, and moral desert seems to require that the doer be the enjoyer.

Buddhism answers with three named devices. The **causal continuum (santāna)** locates memory within one stream: the earlier experience conditions a later cognition that presents itself as recollection, so no permanent subject is required. **Similarity (sādrśya)** explains recognition: a later causal phase resembling an earlier one is conventionally taken as numerically the same, which is why the flame and the river look like single things. **Reconnection (pratisandhāna)** extends continuity across the discontinuities of sleep and death, and Yogācāra supplements it with store-consciousness (*ālaya-vijñāna*) carrying seeds (*bīja*), a conditioned transforming stream rather than a disguised self.

The resulting position is deliberately a middle: the later subject is *neither strictly the same as nor wholly other than* the earlier one (*na sa eva na cānyah*). Strict identity would be eternalism; strict difference would destroy responsibility.

Critically, the reply is strong against the demand for a **carrier** and weak against the demand for a **subject**. Nyāya's residual force is that a series may explain why a memory occurs without explaining how it is *owned*, and Advaita presses further that the unity of experience seems to need a witness.

The defensible verdict is that Buddhism explains personal identity successfully as continuity, while conceding that ownership is a conventional designation rather than an ultimate fact.

Why this earns marks. It states the objection with named opponents, answers with three distinct technical devices rather than one, gives the middle formula in its canonical phrasing, and separates what the reply achieves from what it concedes.

PYQ 9 · 2022 · Q6(a) · 20 marks · Buddhism

Question, as printed: How compatible is Buddhist theory of momentariness with their theory of Karma? In this regard how do Buddhists respond to objections raised by their opponents? Critically discuss.

Demand decoded. Three demands: assess compatibility, report the responses, and criticise. The second demand requires *named* opponents; the third requires a verdict that is graded rather than triumphant.

Model answer (20 marks, 340-400 words).

The tension is genuine. Momentariness (*kṣaṇikavāda*) holds that whatever is real is momentary; action and moral consequence (*karma*) requires that the fruit of an act reach the one who performed it. If the agent perishes with the act, the recipient appears to be someone else, and moral desert collapses.

The Buddhist position. Buddhism refuses the disjunction on which the objection rests. The relation between the acting stage and the receiving stage is *neither identity nor utter difference* - *na sa eva na cānyaḥ*. Strict identity would reinstate the eternal self (*ātman*) already denied; strict difference would make reward and punishment fall on a stranger. What holds them together is the causal continuum (*santāna*): the fruit is received by the stream that the earlier stage conditioned. The illustration is one lamp lighting another - not the same flame, not an unrelated one. Rebirth is relinking (*pratisandhāna*) of one series to another rather than transmigration, so nothing crosses over. Moral quality itself is located in intention (*cetanā*), a formation among the aggregates. Yogācāra adds store-consciousness (*ālaya-vijñāna*) carrying seeds (*bīja*) to explain why latent potential survives long intervals.

Opponents and responses. Nyāya, in the Vātsyāyana-Uddyotakara-Udayana line, argues from recognition, memory and desert to an enduring self; the Buddhist replies with the series and with similarity (*sādṛśya*), which explains why a later similar phase is taken as the same. Kumārila Bhaṭṭa argues that duty and cognition require a persisting subject; Dignāga and Dharmakīrti reply that the subject is a constructed unity imposed on a stream of momentary cognitions. Śaṅkara-type Advaita argues that bondage and release cannot belong to no one; the two-truths reply is that persons and practice are valid designations at conventional truth while nothing has intrinsic nature at ultimate truth.

Critical verdict. The compatibility is real but asymmetric. Buddhism explains **succession** - why this fruit follows that act - with unusual precision, and protects impermanence and responsibility simultaneously. What it explains less convincingly is **ownership**: causal continuity shows why a later stage inherits, but not obviously why it *deserves*. The Buddhist rejoinder, that desert is a conventional notion tracking causal continuity and that the demand for ultimate desert presupposes an ultimate subject, is coherent. The doctrines are therefore compatible, at the price of relocating moral desert to conventional truth.

Why this earns marks. It states the tension precisely, resolves it through the canonical middle formula, names three distinct opponents with their specific arguments and the specific Buddhist replies, adds intention as the locus of moral quality, and closes with a graded verdict that identifies exactly what is and is not secured.

Question, as printed: Explain Buddhist concept of Triratna and their internal relation. Critically examine the consistency of Triratnas with the Buddhist concept of No-soul (Nairātmyavāda).

Demand decoded. Two tasks, and the first is usually done badly. "Internal relation" is not a list of three items; it asks how the three depend on one another.

Model answer (15 marks, 250-300 words).

The Three Jewels (*Triratna*) are the Buddha, the Dharma and the Saṅgha, the threefold refuge of the Buddhist practitioner.

Internal relation. They form a functional triad rather than three parallel objects of devotion. The Buddha is the one who discovered and demonstrated the path; the Dharma is the teaching and the truth it states, and is what actually liberates; the Saṅgha is the community that preserves, transmits and exemplifies the teaching. The dependence therefore runs in two directions. In order of origin it is Buddha → Dharma → Saṅgha, since the teaching derives from the awakening and the community from the teaching. In order of access it is Saṅgha → Dharma → Buddha, since a present-day practitioner reaches the teaching through the community that preserved it. What liberates is identified as the Dharma, which is why refuge is not devotion to a person.

Consistency with no-self. The objection is immediate: if there is no self, who takes refuge? Buddhism answers that the refuge-taker is the **conventional person**, a designated person (*prajñapti-puruṣa*) upon the five aggregates, not an ultimately real soul. That is all refuge requires, because what is needed is a causal series capable of being conditioned by instruction - and intention and dispositions are themselves aggregates.

Far from conflicting, the two doctrines cohere: no-self purifies refuge of ego-metaphysics. Refuge is not the surrender of a soul to a saviour but the reorientation of a stream by a teaching.

Critically, the reply relocates the practitioner to conventional truth, so the Advaitic pressure about the unity of the practising subject remains - a cost, not an inconsistency.

Why this earns marks. It answers "internal relation" with two directions of dependence rather than a list, identifies the Dharma as the liberating member, answers the consistency challenge with the technical term for the conventional person, and concedes the surviving pressure without conceding the charge.

Question, as printed: "Ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation of suffering." Present an account of Buddhist soteriology in the light of above statement.

Demand decoded. A quotation-anchored question. The examiner is testing whether the candidate can show that ignorance is *causally productive* rather than merely absent knowledge, and can then present the whole path as the removal of that cause.

Model answer (20 marks, 340-400 words).

The quoted statement is not an epistemic slogan but a causal thesis: misreading how things exist is itself the engine of suffering, and correcting the misreading dismantles it.

Why ignorance is productive. Ignorance (*avidyā*) is not blankness. It is the active misconstrual of conditioned processes as stable possessions - treating what is dependently arisen as though it had intrinsic nature and belonged to an owner. That misconstrual generates appropriation: what is taken as "mine" is defended, pursued and mourned. This is why ignorance heads the twelve links (*dvādaśa-nidāna*), conditioning formations, consciousness, name-and-form, the six sense-bases, contact, feeling, craving, clinging, becoming, birth, and ageing-and-death.

Where the chain can be cut. Feeling (*vedanā*) arises unavoidably from contact; craving (*tṛṣṇā*) does not arise unavoidably from feeling. That gap is the operative joint, and the Noble Eightfold Path (*āryāṣṭāṅgamārga*) is built to work on it. Grouped under three trainings, wisdom (right view, right intention) attacks ignorance directly, ethical discipline (right speech, action, livelihood) removes the conduct that continually renews craving, and meditative discipline (right effort, mindfulness, concentration) stabilises the attention in which feeling is prevented from hardening into demand.

Why cessation follows. The reverse order (*pratiloma*) of the chain states that with the cessation of ignorance, formations cease, and so on to the cessation of ageing-and-death. Cessation is therefore not an additional event to be hoped for; it is entailed by removing a condition in a dependently arisen series. This converts the third Noble Truth from an assertion into a consequence, and it is exactly what the quoted sentence claims.

What liberation is. Cessation of conditioned suffering (*nirvāṇa*) is the extinction of attachment, aversion and delusion. Since the self was never found, nothing is annihilated; the process of grasping simply ceases. The practitioner is the conventional person, and continuity of practice is carried by the causal series (*santāna*), not by a soul.

Critical assessment. The soteriology is unusually tight: diagnosis, cause, cessation and therapy are one argument, and the metaphysics of impermanence and no-self are entailments of the therapeutic claim rather than additions to it. Its contested point is whether knowledge alone, however transformative, can uproot deeply conditioned craving; the tradition answers by making insight inseparable from conduct and attention, which is why the path has eight factors and not one.

Why this earns marks. It converts the quotation into a causal claim and defends it, uses the twelve links and the reverse order to make cessation an entailment, maps the eightfold path onto the exact joint it targets, and finishes with a critical point that arises from the doctrine rather than from outside it.

Question, as printed: How do the two schools of Buddhism arrive at two opposed conclusions, namely "everything is void" and "everything is real" from the same doctrine of *Pratītyasamutpāda*? Answer with arguments.

Demand decoded. "Answer with arguments" forbids a descriptive contrast. The task is to show *how* one premise supports two conclusions, which means locating the extra premise on which the schools differ.

Model answer (15 marks, 250-300 words).

Both conclusions start from dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*): whatever arises does so in dependence on conditions. They diverge because they apply different criteria of the **ultimately real** to that shared premise.

"Everything is void" - Mādhyamika. To possess intrinsic nature (*svabhāva*) is to exist through oneself; what exists through itself does not await conditions; everything conditioned awaits conditions; therefore nothing conditioned has intrinsic nature; to lack intrinsic nature is to be empty. Nāgārjuna accordingly identifies the dependently arisen with the empty (*śūnya*). The criterion of ultimacy here is **independence**, and dependence excludes it.

"Everything is real" - Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika. These schools accept the same causal premise and infer that precisely because things arise causally, they are real *as conditioned entities*. Vaibhāṣika holds direct realism about *dharma*s and affirms *sarvam asti*, that *dharma*s of the three times have some mode of existence; Sautrāntika restricts full existence to the present and holds that external objects are inferred from the form (*ākāra*) borne by cognition. The criterion of ultimacy here is **causal efficacy**, and dependence supplies it.

Why this is not a contradiction. The two answer different questions. "Everything is void" answers *does anything possess intrinsic nature?* "Everything is real" answers *is anything causally efficacious?* The realists deny permanence, not causal reality; the Mādhyamika denies intrinsic nature, not conventional functioning. The two truths make this explicit: at conventional truth things function; at ultimate truth none has own-being.

The genuine dispute is therefore not verbal but criterial - whether causal efficacy is sufficient for ultimate status, or whether independence is required.

Why this earns marks. It isolates the shared premise, exhibits both derivations as arguments, names the two realist schools separately with their distinguishing theses, and resolves the apparent contradiction by identifying the divergent criterion instead of asserting that the schools simply disagree.

Question, as printed: Is Buddhist notion of Nirvāṇa in consonance with their conception of Kṣaṇikavāda (momentariness) and Nairātmyavāda (no-soul theory)? Critically discuss.

Demand decoded. A three-way consistency question with "critically discuss". It differs from the 2018 fifteen-marker by expressly adding momentariness, so the answer must show what *momentariness specifically* contributes rather than treating it as a synonym for no-self.

Model answer (15 marks, 250-300 words).

The three doctrines are not merely compatible; each is required by the others.

What no-self contributes. Cessation of conditioned suffering (*nirvāṇa*) is the extinction of attachment, aversion and delusion, not a possession acquired by an owner. The objection "who attains?" therefore presupposes the very claimant whose removal constitutes the attainment. No permanent self (*nairātmyavāda*) removes the false claimant, and in doing so removes the appropriation that generated craving in the first place.

What momentariness contributes, distinctly. It is not a restatement of no-self. It supplies the positive explanation of *possibility*: only a series of conditioned events can be interrupted by withdrawing a condition. A permanent bondage, or a permanent defilement inhering in a permanent substance, could not be removed at all. Momentariness thus underwrites the third Noble Truth, while no-self underwrites the diagnosis of what must be given up.

How practice is carried. Continuity is supplied by the causal series (*santāna*), the later liberated stream being neither identical with nor unrelated to the earlier bound stream. Theravāda classifications treat *nibbāna* as unconditioned (*asaṃskṛta*) - outside the dependent series, not a substance with properties. Nāgārjuna adds that *saṃsāra* and *nirvāṇa* are not two independent realms; the difference lies in how dependent reality is grasped.

Critically. Two costs remain. The first-person claim "I am liberated" is explained only as a conventional index within the stream, and the Advaitin presses that the unity of experience still requires a witness. Buddhism answers by refusal rather than by explanation, on the ground that a witness would be one more reification.

The verdict is consonance, purchased by relocating the liberated subject to conventional truth.

Why this earns marks. It differentiates the distinct contributions of no-self and momentariness instead of treating them as one point, handles the unconditioned classification without error, cites Nāgārjuna's non-duality of *saṃsāra* and *nirvāṇa*, and states the surviving Advaitic pressure as a cost rather than a refutation.

PYQ 14 · 2018 · Q5(d) · 10 marks · Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika (supporting routed question)

Question, as printed: How do the Buddhists and the Nyāya philosophers explain our knowledge of 'the absence of the jar on the table'? Answer in detail. **Routing note:** primary ownership rests with Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika; it is solved here because the Buddhist half is owned by this topic and is the half most often written thinly.

Demand decoded. A two-sided comparative question. Give each side's account of *how the cognition arises*, not merely its ontology of absence.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

Nyāya. Absence (*abhāva*) is admitted as a real category. In "there is no jar on the table", the table is the locus (*anuyogin*) and the jar is the counterpositive (*pratiyogin*) whose absence qualifies that locus, so absence-cognition has structured intentional content rather than blankness. No independent means of knowledge called non-cognition is required: under suitable conditions the same perceptual situation that presents the empty locus presents jar-absence through the qualifier-qualified relation (*viśeṣaṇa-viśeṣya-bhāva*). The conditions are that the jar would have been perceptible if present, that the locus is available, and that the senses are unobstructed. Where the missing item is itself inferential, its absence may be inferentially established.

Buddhists. No separately existing negative entity is admitted. The judgement is explained by perception of the positive locus together with non-apprehension of the jar, and is then handled conceptually - by exclusion (*apoha*) and by inference, since the Buddhist epistemologists recognise only perception and inference and reduce non-apprehension to them.

The contrast is thus categorical: Nyāya adds absence to the world; Buddhism adds it only to the conceptual construction of the world.

Why this earns marks. It gives both sides the technical vocabulary their own systems use, explains the mechanism of the cognition rather than only the ontology, and closes with a single sentence that names the precise point of disagreement.

PYQ 15 · 2024 · Q6(a) · 20 marks · Cārvāka (supporting routed question)

Question, as printed: Differentiate between the Cārvākas' refutation of self as a transcendental category and the Buddhist rejection of ātmā. **Routing note:** primary ownership rests with Cārvāka; it is solved here because the Buddhist half of the differentiation is owned by this topic and carries most of the analytical weight.

Demand decoded. "Differentiate" demands fixed axes. The trap is to write two summaries; the reward is for showing that a shared conclusion is reached by opposite routes and issues in opposite consequences.

Model answer (20 marks, 340-400 words).

Both schools deny an eternal self (*ātman*), and there the agreement ends. They differ in method, in what replaces the self, and in what the denial costs.

Method. Cārvāka argues from a restriction of knowledge. Accepting perception as the sole reliable means, and refusing inference independent standing, it holds that no transcendental self is ever perceived; what is observed is a living body in which awareness appears. The denial is therefore **epistemically driven** and reductive. Buddhism argues from an exhaustive analysis. The person is divided into five aggregates (*pañca-skandha*) - form, feeling, perception, formations, consciousness - each found impermanent, unsatisfactory when grasped and not fit to be owned; and no sixth item is discovered. The denial is therefore **analytically driven**, and Buddhism accepts inference as one of its two means of valid knowledge.

What replaces the self. For Cārvāka the replacement is the **body**: consciousness is treated as arising from the organised material elements, as intoxicating power arises from ingredients that individually lack it. For Buddhism the replacement is a **process**: the person is a designation (*prajñapti*) on a causal series (*santāna*), illustrated by the chariot analogy of the *Milinda-pañha*. Buddhism explicitly refuses the materialist reduction, since consciousness is one aggregate conditioned by others rather than a by-product of body alone.

Consequences. This is where the differentiation earns its marks. Cārvāka's denial abolishes rebirth, moral consequence and liberation together; ethics becomes prudential and the goal becomes worldly well-being. Buddhism's denial is designed precisely to *preserve* rebirth, moral consequence and liberation without a bearer: the

fruit falls on the stream that the acting stage conditioned, on the formula that the later stage is neither the same nor another (*na sa eva na cānyaḥ*), with moral quality located in intention (*cetanā*).

Assessment. Cārvāka's position is economical and immune to the charge of speculative surplus, but it purchases economy by rejecting inference, which its rivals argue is self-defeating. Buddhism's position is more demanding, since it must explain memory, recognition and desert without an owner, and Nyāya's charge that a series cannot own what it transmits retains force.

The differentiation is therefore not one of degree. Cārvāka rejects the self to shrink the world to what perception delivers; Buddhism rejects it to redescribe the world as process while keeping everything the self was invoked to explain.

Why this earns marks. It uses three fixed axes rather than two summaries, names the technical devices on each side, identifies the decisive contrast in consequences rather than in doctrine alone, and ends with a balanced assessment that gives each position its characteristic strength and cost.

PYQ 16 · 2025 · Q5(b) · 10 marks · Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika (supporting routed question)

Question, as printed: Present an exposition of the debate between Naiyāyikas and Buddhists with reference to the notion of Pramāṇa and Pramāṇaphala. **Routing note:** primary ownership rests with Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika; it is solved here because the Buddhist side of the debate is owned by this topic through the Dignāga-Dharmakīrti material.

Demand decoded. "Exposition of the debate" requires both positions and the reason they differ. The reason is metaphysical, and saying so is what lifts the answer above a definitional contrast.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

Nyāya. The knower (*pramātṛ*), the means of valid knowledge (*pramāṇa*), the object (*prameya*) and the resulting true cognition (*pramā* or *pramāṇaphala*) are analytically distinct factors in a realist cognitive episode. The operative instrument or causal complex is the *pramāṇa*; true cognition is its fruit. Means and result are therefore different.

Buddhists. Dignāga tightens the relation so that the instrument of knowledge and its result are not ultimately different. The resultant cognition - the determination of the object together with the self-awareness of cognition (*svasaṃvedana*) - is non-different from the cognitive event that functions as *pramāṇa*. The analysis into instrument (*karaṇa*) and result (*phala*) is a conceptual overlay on a single momentary cognition.

Why they differ. The disagreement is downstream of metaphysics. Nyāya has an enduring knower who uses a real instrument on a real object; Buddhism, having denied the permanent self and admitted only momentary events, has no bearer to hold the fourfold apparatus apart. Nyāya is instrumentally realist; Buddhist epistemology is cognition-centred.

Why this earns marks. It presents both positions in their own vocabulary, identifies the Buddhist thesis precisely as non-difference rather than as identity, and explains the disagreement by tracing it to the dispute over the self instead of leaving it as a clash of definitions.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE - SIX MODELS

These six questions are original practice items written in UPSC style. They are not previous-year questions and are not represented as such.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Explain the two senses of the Middle Path (*madhyamā pratipad*) in Buddhism. Why is the doctrinal sense indispensable to the practical one?

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

The Middle Path operates in two registers.

Practically, it rejects sensual indulgence and self-mortification, replacing both with the Noble Eightfold Path (*āryaṣṭāṅgamārga*) grouped under wisdom (right view, right intention), ethical discipline (right speech, action, livelihood) and meditative discipline (right effort, mindfulness, concentration). The rejection is diagnostic: indulgence

feeds craving, while mortification exhausts the practitioner without touching it.

Doctrinally, it rejects eternalism (*śāśvatavāda*) and annihilationism (*ucchedavāda*), replacing both with dependent origination and conditioned continuity.

The doctrinal sense is indispensable because the practical path is unintelligible without it. If a permanent self existed, training could not transform it, and the third Noble Truth would fail. If nothing continued, discipline could accumulate no result, and the fourth would fail. Only conditioned continuity - change without a permanent bearer, and continuity without annihilation - makes a path both necessary and effective.

Both senses share one logic: Buddhism denies the hidden assumption common to each pair of extremes rather than choosing between them.

Why this earns marks. It gives both senses with their positive content, then answers the "why" with a specific structural dependence rather than a general remark about coherence.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: "Buddhist epistemology is not a shortened Nyāya list." Examine this claim with reference to the two means of valid knowledge and the exclusion theory of meaning.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

The claim is correct, and the reason is structural rather than numerical.

Dignāga and Dharmakīrti admit two means of valid knowledge because they hold that the number of means is fixed by the number of **object-types**. There are exactly two: the unique particular (*svalakṣaṇa*), which is momentary, causally efficient and ineffable, grasped by non-conceptual perception; and the constructed general character (*sāmānyalakṣaṇa*), grasped by inference. Comparison, postulation, non-apprehension and testimony are reduced to these, not omitted from a list.

The exclusion theory (*apoha*) confirms the point. Since only unique particulars are ultimately real, a general term cannot denote a real universal; "cow" functions as "not-non-cow", generality being constructed negatively upon shared causal capacity.

Both theses follow from momentariness and no-self, which is also why the instrument of knowledge is held to be non-different from its result. A shortened Nyāya list would still contain an enduring knower and real universals; Buddhist epistemology contains neither.

Why this earns marks. It refutes the claim by exhibiting a different principle of individuation, links two doctrines to the same metaphysical source, and names the consequence for *pramāṇaphala*.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Analyse the four schools of Buddhism as an argumentative escalation rather than as a classification. What does each successive position gain and lose?

Model answer (15 marks, 250-300 words).

The fourfold matrix is a philosophical doxography, and its explanatory value lies in the fact that each position is generated by an objection the previous one cannot absorb.

Vaibhāṣika holds direct realism about external *dharma*s and affirms *sarvam asti*, that *dharma*s of past, present and future have some mode of existence. It **gains** a genuine object for every cognition and a real relation between a past act and its future fruit. It **loses** ontological economy and strains momentariness, since extending existence across the three times sits awkwardly with strict one-moment duration.

Sautrāntika answers by restricting full existence to the present. Since the object-moment has ceased when its cognition arises, cognition bears only the object's form (*ākāra*), from which the external object is inferred. It **gains** consistency with momentariness. It **loses** direct access, and now owes an account of why the inferred cause should correspond to the form it produces.

Yogācāra presses exactly there: if all that is ever given is the form, the external object performs no explanatory work. Representation-only (*vijñaptimātra*) **gains** economy, and explains order through store-consciousness (*ālaya-vijñāna*)

and seeds (*bīja*). It **loses** the easy explanation of intersubjective agreement, which must now be derived from shared karmic conditioning, and it exposes consciousness itself to the charge of reification.

Mādhyamika presses that charge: even consciousness lacks intrinsic nature. Emptiness **gains** complete freedom from reification, including the emptiness of emptiness. It **loses** any positive ultimate, and must defend a non-implicative negation (*prasajya-pratiṣedha*) against the objection that denying all four corners either says nothing or refutes itself.

Read as an escalation, the four schools display one method - remove whatever the analysis shows to be unnecessary - applied with increasing severity.

Why this earns marks. It supplies the objection that drives each transition, states a specific gain and a specific cost for every school, and ends with the methodological unity that makes the sequence an argument rather than a list.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: "The doctrine of two truths is what separates emptiness from nihilism." Critically examine, with reference to the four-cornered analysis.

Model answer (15 marks, 250-300 words).

The claim is substantially correct, though it needs a supplement.

The problem. The four-cornered analysis (*catuṣkoṭī*) sets out four alternatives - it is, it is not, it both is and is not, it neither is nor is not - and Nāgārjuna denies all four. To a realist this looks like the abolition of every position, hence nihilism, and the further charge that the denial is itself a thesis, so the claim to have no thesis (*pratijñā*) is self-refuting.

The first defence is the negation type. Madhyamaka negation is non-implicative (*prasajya-pratiṣedha*) rather than implicative (*paryudāsa-pratiṣedha*), and it is **scoped**: the four corners are denied of things taken as possessing intrinsic nature (*svabhāva*). Denying them therefore withdraws a malformed question rather than asserting four incompatible propositions, and no fifth positive thesis is installed. Nāgārjuna's supplement is that his own words are empty too, so they generate no ontological commitment; empty utterance cures empty reification as one magically created figure may counteract another (*nirmitaka*).

The second defence is the two truths, and this is what the claim identifies. At conventional truth (*saṃvṛti-satya*), persons, causation, moral consequence, compassion and the path all function; at ultimate truth (*paramārtha-satya*), nothing possesses own-being. Conventional truth is not falsehood but the operative domain of Buddhist practice. Without it, the fourfold denial would indeed leave nothing standing.

Critically, the two truths are necessary but not sufficient: the negation nuance must also be stated, or the doctrine still looks self-refuting. And whether a non-implicative negation can be sustained without covertly functioning as a thesis remains disputed, as the internal Prāsaṅgika-Svātantrika division shows.

The accurate verdict is that the two truths block nihilism, while the scoped negation blocks self-refutation, and emptiness needs both.

Why this earns marks. It states the objection in both its forms, distinguishes two distinct defences and assigns each to the charge it answers, and refines the quoted claim instead of simply endorsing it.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Evaluate the claim that Buddhism preserves everything the self was invoked to explain, while dispensing with the self itself.

Model answer (20 marks, 340-400 words).

The claim states Buddhism's ambition accurately. The question is whether the ambition is achieved, and the honest answer is: largely, but not entirely.

What the self was invoked to explain. In the realist systems, an enduring self (*ātman*) accounts for four things: continuity through time, memory and recognition, the justice of moral consequence, and the unity of one experiencing life.

How Buddhism replaces each. Continuity is supplied by the causal series (*santāna*), whose successive members are similar enough (*sādṛśya*) to be designated as one thing - the flame and the river. Memory is a later cognition conditioned by an earlier experience within the same stream, extended across discontinuities by reconnection (*pratisandhāna*) and, in Yogācāra, by store-consciousness (*ālaya-vijñāna*) carrying seeds (*bīja*). Moral consequence is preserved by the formula that the later stage is neither the same nor another (*na sa eva na cānyaḥ*), with moral quality located in intention (*cetanā*), itself an aggregate. Practice and refuge are preserved by the conventional person (*prajñapti-puruṣa*).

Where the replacement succeeds. It succeeds against the demand for a **carrier**. Every function the realist assigned to a substance is discharged by a causal relation, and the resulting system is more economical: it explains bondage and release with the same apparatus, since only a conditioned series can be interrupted by removing a condition.

Where it is pressed hardest. Two functions resist. First, **ownership**: Nyāya, in the Vātsyāyana-Uddyotakara-Udayana line, argues that a series may explain why a memory occurs without explaining whose memory it is, and that desert requires more than inheritance. Second, **unity**: Śaṅkara-type Advaita argues that the presentation of a manifold as one field requires a self-luminous witness, and that denying the self presupposes it. Buddhism answers the first by treating ownership as a conventional designation and the second by refusing the witness as one more reification - coherent answers that relocate rather than discharge the demand.

Verdict. The claim holds for continuity, memory-transmission, karmic inheritance and practice, and holds only at the conventional level for ownership and unity. Buddhism therefore dispenses with the self successfully as an explanatory posit while conceding that some of the work it did survives as convention rather than as ultimate fact - which is why the dispute with Nyāya and Advaita has never been settled by either side.

Why this earns marks. It converts an evaluative claim into a checklist of four explanatory functions, supplies the specific Buddhist replacement for each with technical terms, separates successes from residues, names the opponents who press the residues, and delivers a differentiated rather than a global verdict.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: Compare the Buddhist and Jaina responses to the problem of change and permanence, and assess which secures the reality of the world at lower philosophical cost.

Model answer (20 marks, 340-400 words).

Both are non-Vedic renouncer traditions, both deny a creator, and both must explain how a thing can change and still be spoken of as the same. Their solutions are opposites.

The Jaina solution. The real (*sat*) possesses origination (*utpāda*), decay (*vyaya*) and persistence (*dhrauvya*) together. Permanence belongs to substance (*dravya*) and change to modes (*pariyāya*), so the gold persists while bracelet gives way to ring. Since the real has innumerable aspects, cognition is standpoint-relative (*naya*) and assertion carries the operator *syāt*, generating the sevenfold predication. Reality is many-sided (*anekāntavāda*), and the soul (*jīva*) is a real conscious substance obscured by action-matter.

The Buddhist solution: deny the persisting substance altogether. Whatever is conditioned is impermanent, and the criterion of the real as causally efficient (*sat* = *arthakriyā-samartha*) radicalises this into momentariness (*kṣaṇikavāda*), since a permanent entity can produce its effect neither all at once (*yaugapadya*) nor successively (*krama*) without ceasing to be permanent. Apparent persistence is a causal series (*santāna*) of sufficiently similar moments; the person is a designation on five aggregates; no soul is admitted.

The costs, weighed. Jainism secures the world cheaply in ontology and expensively in logic. Nothing needs to be re-described: things really persist and really change. But predication must be permanently qualified, the schema of assertion becomes sevenfold, and the system must carry six substances, innumerable souls and material action-matter. Buddhism secures the world cheaply in logic and expensively in re-description. Assertion stays ordinary and the ontology is austere - momentary causally efficient events - but almost every ordinary notion must be relocated to conventional truth: the same thing, the same person, the rememberer, the deserver.

Assessment. If "reality of the world" means the truth of ordinary claims taken at face value, Jainism secures it at lower cost, because it never demotes them. If it means an ontology free of unexplained composites and unverifiable substances, Buddhism secures it at lower cost, because it posits less. The decisive contrast is methodological: Jainism qualifies the *sentence* to save the *world*; Buddhism qualifies the *world* to save the *sentence*.

The standard error must be avoided: Jainism affirms the soul emphatically, and only Buddhism denies it.

Why this earns marks. It states both solutions in their own technical vocabulary, converts "cost" into two explicit currencies rather than leaving it vague, delivers a conditional verdict that depends on how the question is read, and closes by disarming the comparison error that examiners most often penalise.